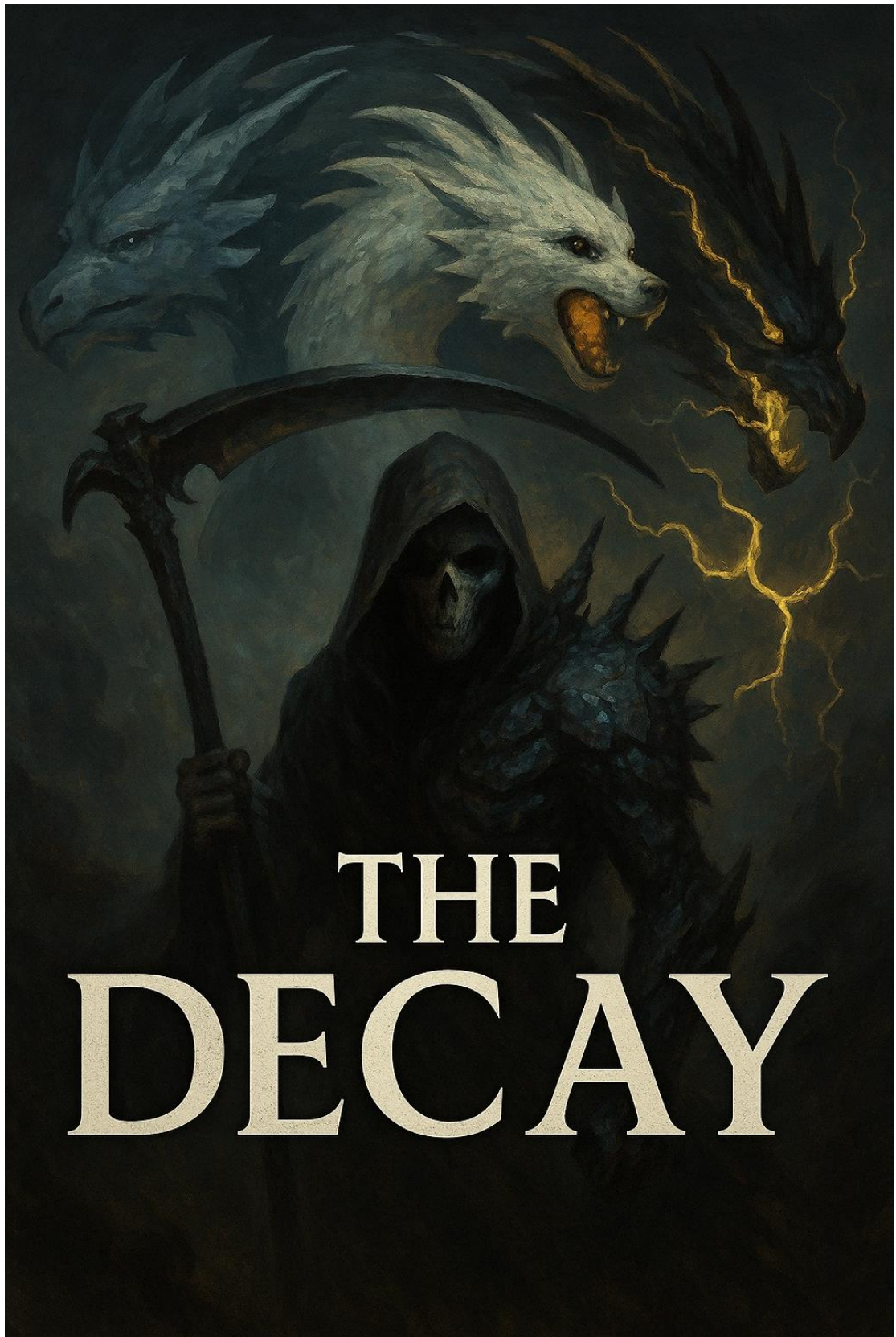




The Decay

Once, in a distant village, lived a very wicked man. He was up to his words, but what made him unlikable was that his words were never good. He was very unstable, not psychologically, but because he could never stay in a place for long as he sought adventure all the time.

Even though his mother went to Kuwait for job purposes about 12 years ago when he was just 2 and then never came back, his father never made him feel his mother's absence. But now, due to his behaviors, even his father was fed up with him.

His name was Rosé, by the way, but due to his not-so-rose-like behaviors, he was called Wither by the entire village he lived in.

One subtle morning, just like any other in his life, he woke up in his room, which was made into an attic by his father, and began his search for something really exciting. But then, unlike any other day, this time he decided to go into the basement his father had strictly prohibited him from going into. The door to the unknown was directly below the staircase.

As soon as he touched the knob, it felt hot. He checked the temperature with a laboratory thermometer he had stolen the day before. To his surprise, the temperature was beyond the record of that digital thermometer.

"Why am I not in the ashes till now?" wondering, he somehow twisted the doorknob and opened the door to see literal nothingness, all dark.

He fetched a really bright torchlight from his storeroom and turned it on facing the basement. To his amazement, the torchlight never turned on when it was clearly operating a second ago. But as soon as he let his hand loose in disappointment, the torchlight facing the ground now suddenly lit up.

He was more than confused till now. He had way too many questions and a bit of fear. But yeah, he entered the door.

As soon as he did, the door slammed closed right behind him, and he could not open it. Now really scared, he began climbing down.

An hour passed, supposedly because no electronics were working in this place. And then two, and then three. But the stairs seemed to not end. After a few more hours, he could hear screams and weird noises from the void.

He thought it clever to just turn around now, but he was stunned to see that the door was right behind him, as if he had only descended a single step in all this time.

As soon as he opened the door, he saw that there was not a trace of his house there, but a huge library, stories tall.

He was not in a condition to think anymore, but this was exactly what he craved — excitement — so he didn't complain either.

Among hundreds of thousands of books there, one caught his attention: "The Ancestry of the Stitans."

He saw the book's title glowing in yellow from a distance. He took an elevator there, to the book which seemed to be on the uppermost floor.

As soon as he touched it, the book vanished.

Then a librarian came from the same door as him, and something that seemed like some dense black smoke carried him directly towards there.

He said with a very deep voice, "You are the 96th Stitan, son of Caliber Stitan and grandson of Kuro Stitan, aren't you?"

Rosé said in a very confused and scared voice, "Yes?"

The librarian said, "Well, every Stitan is told to keep their descendants away from this place until they are 18, but as you are here already, I know you have many, many questions. Come with me to the attic."

Rosé went to the attic and saw exactly a hundred books, but visible from a distance was the same, "The Ancestry of the Stitans."

The librarian said, "You are very lucky, kid, that you descended exactly 6969 steps before turning around, because even one step more or less, and anything could have happened to you. There lives a monster in the void that eats everybody that takes the wrong number of steps. That's why every Stitan is told to keep their descendants away from this place and make them carefully descend the exact number of stairs when they turn 18."

"Why come here? And who are you?" Rosé asked.

He replied, "I'm Kuro's father and your great-grandfather. Call me Andera. As for why come here, it's for that book. Every Stitan has to come here to read that book when they are 18. And that book contains answers to all of your questions. After my demise, Kuro will be the new deity of the Stitans, and the role passes on in the lineage on the oldest-son basis. Your lineage is special, kid. Now go and read that book."

Hesitating, Rosé opened that book.

The first page stated the curse to the first Stitan by a demon named Piaggio, the deity of darkness, because he was jealous of how kind he was and how he was a sheer devotee of Jamla, the goddess of light.

After the curse, the entire Stitan lineage got the power to manipulate darkness, but their powers were mostly about killing others, and when they hurt others using their powers, it would directly empower Piaggio.

The rest of the pages also had important information, and then came the 69th page.

At the end of that page, it was written:

"If used more than a limit, the Titans' powers of darkness will start consuming themselves, and after a point, their bodies will be taken over by Piaggio himself, and their souls will be trapped inside the Underworld for eternity. To revert the process and bring the trapped soul back..."

And then Rosé flipped the page, and the 70th page was missing.

"Where is the 70th page, Mr. Great Grandad?" asked Rosé to Andera.

Andera replied, "Piaggio's strongest soldier, Ramsey, stole it years ago. It was the 23rd Titan that defended the book, but Ramsey was successful in tearing one of the most important pages in the book, the number 70."

Rose was curious. "Hey, I got those darkness powers too?"

"Of course you do, but there's a chance that you might not be able to use it. It depends on one's willpower, and also you will not be able to do it properly now as you're not 18. Try practicing now and be ready to unleash your true potential in adulthood."

Although excited, Rosé had other plans. He wanted to free his and his cousins' descendants from the curse.

The only way to do that, as per written in the book, was to find Lucas, the king of the gods.

He returned to his house and looked at the clock and saw only a second had passed since he had left. He was not surprised because he had seen even bigger things than this.

He spent the rest of the day in the attic until his father came in the evening, and they slept after dinner.

In the morning, he woke up so early — earlier than he ever had — packed his bags, and departed for Mount Olympus, Greece, where he could find Lucas.

He lived in the hilly terrains of Canada, and going all the way to Greece was no small feat.

He had no idea how he could reach Greece, being a 14-year-old with no national identity or passport whatsoever.

He just got himself packed and made his way to Ottawa on foot.

He had no way to go past here now, but he could not lose hope just yet.

He threw his bags in a trash can near Lake Superior and snuck into a plane that was going to Poland.

He got into the plane and sat beside an old man pretending to be his grandson. He even snuck back out, and ahead of him was a land unknown that he had never experienced before.

He had a plan this time. He was like the freest person on earth who never made a plan in his life, and if someone else planned something for him, he would just knowingly reject.

He planned to sail from the Baltic Sea through the English Channel and the Atlantic Ocean to the Mediterranean Sea, through the Strait of Gibraltar, and finally to Greece.

This plan was perfect, or so he thought.

He made it like a breeze through the Baltic Sea, but a problem arose at the little channel between the nations of England and France. It was guarded by hundreds of thousands of navy soldiers from both sides.

His tiny wreck of a boat was too noticeable, so he had to take a quick break in Germany.

He abandoned his boat and took a little piece of bamboo and made a really hard decision to swim the entire channel off using the bamboo as a snorkel.

He was strangely agile from his very childhood, and this was one of the things he used to do at home — snorkeling.

He was too confident that he could do it, but as soon as he touched his foot to the seawater, he instantly fatigued.

He was really amazed by what just happened. Where did his endurance, his skills, and his experience go?

He took no time to realize that he snorkeled in fresh water at home, but never in the sea.

What was the difference? Salt?

Salt didn't fatigue him, or did it?

After thinking for a bit, he realized that he had never tried sea salt before, he had only eaten rock salt in his life, so why was it so that he could not be at the sea?

He was utterly confused, but wait — he realized what one of the pages of the book said: every Stitan shall be intolerant to the sheer energy of the sea. Sensing this, Rosé was now really broken down.

Now, he saw no way to reach Olympus, and he couldn't even think of going back. He was completely stuck in the middle.

Suddenly, he realized that he was no ordinary being, but he didn't know how to use his powers yet.

He was about to lose hope, but a man in a black hood was spying on him, ever since he landed in Germany.

He slowly threw his feet towards Rosé, but that panicked him af — he thought he was dead — until the man dropped his hood.

"Dad?"

Rosé's mind was not working. He was extremely confused by how his dad was present here.

Caliber reassured Rosé and told him to go back.

"No, I want to free my and my cousin's upcoming children from this filthy curse, and you better not try to stop me!" Rosé raged.

Caliber, with an evil smile, said, "Oh well, what do you think is bad about this curse, huh? We are getting free powers, becoming unique from the entirety of the world. All this struggle, all this sacrifice for what, to make us lose what makes us so special? You are just a disgrace to exist."

Rosé was now confused.

He asked his internal self what he was doing all this for.

No answer.

The entire environment fell into awkward silence.

He didn't know why he was doing this. He just had to.

He just... changing the topic, asked, "Why the hell do I feel so drained by the sea? I mean, in the book it said that we shall be weak to sea, but I don't see the connection here."

Caliber said, "I don't know. I also got all my knowledge from that same book. I am not even supposed to know anything except for what is written in the book."

Rosé just had no hope... until he farted.

His fart was like black dead smoke, just like the one he had seen Andera riding on.

He knew exactly what he had to do.

He tried feeling the dark powers enclosed inside him, and unlike other Stitans at his age, he actually could.

He was somehow able to release the same smoke from his hands.

He rode that cloud and flew away right in front of Caliber's eyes.

Caliber just smirked mysteriously and headed back to his place.

Rosé continued his journey, but he didn't need to worry this time. He could fly over any obstacle.

Soon enough, he found himself in Athens, the capital of Greece.

Please don't dislike my story because I rushed his journey from Canada to Athens a bit too much, but you know, it's hard to take care of every detail. My hands were hurting and it was getting harder to think, I just couldn't come up with any filler.

He now had to grab resources first, like food and stuff, but he had no money.

He sure had to find a way to get it.

He pulled his hand out and pointed it at a shopkeeper, out of reasons I am not able to explain.

Suddenly, similar-looking black smoke shot from his hand, grasping around the neck of the shopkeeper, sucking all life energy from him, killing him on the spot.

His body looked like an old man hungry for days, bones visible through his pale skin.

He felt a surge of regret, as he didn't even mean to kill somebody.
Although his behavior was a bit kind of weird, he was not evil-minded.

He had no choice either.

He robbed the shop and brought himself invisible with his power.

He now rapidly walked to Olympus, in a hope to meet Lucas..... well, he tried to do so!

Actually, he had no clue about the direction, and don't tell me that he could use google maps as the story's timeline is wayyyyyyyyy before mobile phones were invented.

He, clueless, just chose a random direction, and flew his way.

On his way, he noticed a strange phenomenon.

He saw some tribal people, those typical ones with crowns made of bird feathers, pitch-black tanned skin, and ash on their faces.

They were performing a ritual of singing, dancing, and revolving around what seemed like a giant golem statue made of black igneous rocks with magma visible in the cracks.

The wicked Rosé, showing his wickedness, went on and destroyed that golem.

Did I mention that he was an atheist? I don't think I did! Why is it necessary you may ask, because that is the reason why Rosé didn't respect their ritual.

The people were in absolute shock, with sheer terror visible through their eyes.

All of them raged toward Rosé, and Rosé gave an evil smile, fully ready to unleash what he had recently learned.

He killed all of them, and their condition looked the same as that shopkeeper's before.

What happened to him?

His innocent little heart that throbbed twice before hitting an insect?

Well, it looks like this blessing was a curse all along.

His innocence was being devoured by his own powers.

He was turning into a demon.

He noticed patches of crystalline black stones on his left palm and right temple that were like parts of his body as he was not able to scratch it off.

He entered the tribe's hideout, only to be welcomed by more of those people.

Again with an evil smile, he just touched the ground with his palm, and the piece of land below him elevated, taking him off with it.

Then suddenly, the entire ground broke open in a circular area around him, creating a black sinkhole that seemed endless.

“The abyssal suffering!”, he screamed.

All of those people fell into the hole.

Epics have it that those people are still falling to date.

So yes, that abyss was directly controlled by Nykshita, Piaggio's eldest daughter, and his successor who would continue his legacy.

That abyss was made so that those who fall inside it keep falling for eternity.

Not even death can save them from this suffering.

Imagine not being able to move and having to stay like this for eternity, while hunger, thirst, and exhaustion slowly decayed you from inside.
But never being able to actually break free.

It's worse than hell.

Now back to the story, Rosé ventured deep into their cave.

He discovered a wall with some strange, un-understandable language written in glowing purple ink.

Under it was a scythe that suited perfectly for the king of the dark powers.

Rosé picked that scythe up.
As soon as he did, more of his body was infected by the stones, and the scythe started emitting visible dark aura.

He now, destined to reach Lucas, set foot on the base of Olympus how lucky to actually reach there!

#Plotarmour

He had many challenges to face, like difficult terrain, but he made it really easily, thanks to his... fart cloud!

He had, by then, reached halfway.

Olympus was completely banned for tourists, and therefore there was a fungal outgrowth at the place.

There were sensitive fungi that exploded on contact, fungi that released poisonous spores, and more of those.

The fungal outgrowth area had ended, and ahead was Ramsey himself, the right wing of the darkness lord.

Then started a boss music.

And then emerged a bone-chilling fight.

"ABYSSAL SUFFERING!" Rosé screamed.

He was really, really confident in this move he had recently discovered.

Ramsey didn't even really fall.

As Rosé was celebrating his easy victory, Ramsey climbed out of the abyss like nothing had happened.

"I am the master of the dark energy you possess. Really thought you could beat me by this lame move, kid? Mwahahahahaha!"

Rosé was now terrified.

His strongest attack wouldn't even scratch him.

He was about to lose hope and flee, until he realized he still had his last resort — the scythe from earlier.

"Here goes nothing!"

Rosé charged towards Ramsey with a tight hold of the scythe, completely beheading him.

He was radiated by his achievement — until Ramsey's head on the ground suddenly exploded into black smoke.

The smoke gathered on the part of his body where the head should have been.

Soon, the smoke took the form of his head again.

It seemed like it was impossible to kill him.

Suddenly, the scythe glowed enough to blind anybody who looked directly at it.

The body of Ramsey broke down into hundreds of thousands of pieces, but the unimaginable happened after that.

All the pieces of his body came together in the form of a blob and then separated into two.

One side took the form of a white dragon named Munikrishna, and the other became a black dragon named Zaedge.

The debris during their separation became another dragon named Aurem.

Rosé was terrified that those three were going to attack him, but to his surprise, they bowed down and thanked him for freeing them.

They could not speak, being reptiles, so we can just imagine that they were thanking Rosé, and they joined Rosé on his journey.

Aurem had a strange piece of paper in his mouth.

As Rosé checked, he was overjoyed with the sight of page no. 70.

He tried reading it, but it was written in some strange language, like the one in the cave.

He just tugged it inside his pocket and ventured forward.

He was now nearing the summit, finally after days of climbing.

He finally reached the summit, a place seeming like pure heaven: clouds directly atop his head, giant flowers, waterfalls of nectar, and gardens of ice cream.

The dream of every person.

He had no time, though.

He had to find Lucas, so that he could save the future.

Not long after that, he found in the Dandelion Gardens — Jamla, the Light Goddess.

Rosé was stunned by her beauty.

He went close for inspection.

He went and asked where he could find Lucas.

Jamla whispered, "What is this infection all over your body? I can only see your left eye and nothing else. Don't tell me you are one of the Stitans."

Rosé replied, "Of course I am! I am the great-grandson of Andera. You must be Jamla, right, the goddess of light?"

"You look too young to be here, and how did you use your powers already?"

"I know, and I hate it how we are having to suffer from Piaggio's curse. I really want you to help me before I turn adult and change my mind, how I have seen my ancestors do."

Jamla grasped.

She said to Rosé that he was the first Stitan to actually oppose their curse.

The ones before him would just be happy to get free powers.

"But it looks like your soul is soon to be trapped in the underworld. What are you going to do? You should really have avoided using your powers much," Jamla added.

Rosé said, "Stop your yapping and tell me the location of Lucas already."

Jamla pointed at a distant castle.

Rosé happily went to the castle.

He, in a hustle, climbed the first stair leading to the actual castle, but the stair opened wide, creating an abyss that Rosé fell directly into.

Rosé thought this was the end — but turns out it was not an abyss.

It was a finite hole, leading to a dark place with magma everywhere and painful screams audible all over.

It took him no time to realize that this was the Underworld — Piaggio's hideout.

Rosé kept roaming around, fought a lot — a lot — of Underworld monsters, until finally he came face to face with Piaggio himself.

"I'm here to take your head, filthy rat!"

Now, Rosé realized that Piaggio was the one being worshiped by those tribal people because he looked exactly identical to the golem they were performing the ritual around.

Along with him not accepting what Piaggio had given to his lineage, what made Piaggio hate Rosé was for him to destroy his statue and take his beloved weapon, what he called the Scythe of Misery.

An all-out war sparked between Rosé and Piaggio.

Piaggio was really confident that Rosé couldn't defeat him with the power he had gifted him, and also considering his young age of 14, his negligence was what led to his downfall.

He never took Rosé seriously.

Rosé tried his best, but no move of his even scratched Piaggio.

Piaggio started giving a laugh of victory until Munikrishna and Zaedge appeared out of the blue.

Well, this idiom makes no sense as an Underworld doesn't even have a blue in the first place. Whatever,

Piaggio was shocked by the sight of them.

"I am sure I had sealed these immensely chaotic dragons inside Ramsey millennia ago. Don't tell me you defeated him."

"Serves you right, rat. Guys, kill this guy."

Turned out, those were no ordinary reptiles.
They could control an element each.

Munikrishna could manipulate flames, and Zaedge was the master of thunder.

Those two started ramming into Piaggio, causing significant damage.

After a long time, Piaggio was actually able to knock both of the dragons down.

Rosé didn't even know what to do now.

He couldn't hurt the god of darkness with darkness — as it would be like a donkey trying to defeat a human with intelligence.

Suddenly for some reason, we can see an awkward smile and discomfoting chuckle coming from Rosè.

He raised both of his hands, kept his legs apart, and screamed, "*Shin'en no Kumotsu!*"

The entire area around him turned into a pit, similar to the abyss he created.

Bats and black particles filled the place, and strange zombies started climbing up the pit.

The bats infected all demons in the Underworld, and then all of those — millions in numbers — raged towards Piaggio.

After a bit of fighting, they took over Piaggio completely, finally putting an end to his arc.

Now, at Rosé—
Wait, what's wrong?

Rosé is not him anymore.

As warned in the book, Rosé had used his power beyond limits, and his soul was trapped.

This body, though, had become a zombie.
It was destroying everything.

Now, Aurem came and took the torn page from Rosé's pocket and flew straight towards the Forbidden Library and handed the page to Andera.

"Aurem, how come you be free? Don't tell me Caliber's son defeated Ramsey! What about Munikrishna and Zaedge?"

Aurem, unable to speak, put that piece of paper on Andera's hand.

"Number 70?"

Andera quickly grabbed the book, '*The Ancestry of the Stitans*'.

As soon as he placed the page on where it was torn from, it automatically sealed in place and translated to English.

It had instructions on how to bring back a soul trapped by the Darkness Powers.

He now had to leave his library and go to the Underworld.

He flew on his broom and reached the gate to the Underworld — the real way you enter the place — unlike the way Rosè did, through a trap.

He went inside and found the lifeless body of Rosé.

What he did next was do the same tribal dance around this body.

And that's when the curtain falls!

Now for the post-credits!

Andera was actually able to save Rosé from the anomaly, and they finally reached Lucas from the same stairs as mentioned before, and got their curse broken.

They lived happily ever after.

But it begs the question:

What were those tribal people doing?

Were they a part of the Stitan lineage trying to revive somebody that had the same fate as Rosé?

Who was the one they were trying to revive?

And what is the reason Andera knows those dragons?

Make your own theories, don't expect a sequel from me! (• _ •)

Extra bits nobody would read:

So, I just wanted to tell where I got the ideas for this jaw-dropping story.

The concept of a boy with dark powers whose powers consumed him when overused was from my friend, namely Mridul Adhikari, but don't thank him, cuz he sucks.

The 3 dragons were directly from Pokémon Black & White.

Munikrishna is Reshiram — Rishi and Muni are synonymous words for a mage, and

Ram and Krishna are two avatars of the Hindu god Vishnu — so I made Reshiram into Munikrishna.

Zaedge is Zekrom.

How I named him was that "krom" sounds like Chrome, and I prefer Edge over Chrome as a browser, so I made Zekrom into Zaedge.

Aurem is Kyurem.

Even their names sound similar, but what I did was that as Kyurem sounded somewhat similar to Cuprum, I named him Aurem, that sounds like Aurum.

The entire Olympus scene was directly from the platformer extreme demon named "*Throat of the World*" of Geometry Dash, which is the definition of perfection — except it's way too long for me to complete.

The title and some lore drops are from another GD level named "*The Decay*."

The magical scythe was probably from a Roblox experience named "*Blox Fruits*," where there is a rare sword named "*Hollow Scythe*" dropped from a boss named "*Soul Reaper*."

The protagonist is named Rosé after a Blackpink member with the same name, who released a banger song named "*APT*," which was spreading faster than a virus when I was writing this story.

Also, I showed this story's prototype to many people before finalizing it, and I saw one common complain from most of them, that I never explained the reason for the Stitans' intolerance towards sea salt. Lemme just come up with a slight explanation. In Hindu mythology (I am from the said background), sea salt is considered a symbol for purity, often being used in prayers and rituals. As you know that the powers of Stitans comes from a demon, Piaggeo, it makes sense for them to be intolerant to sea salt. Well, this is all some goofy excuse, I just wanted to replicate how One piece did it, just to lengthen the story, and reference my favorite manga.

The rest is original — as much as I think.

The End :)



Don't ask me what the symbols are
XD